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EXPLORING AFFECTIVE DIMENSIONS OF THE ECOLOGICAL CRISIS IN DESIGN: A REFLECTIVE MANIFESTO WRITING WORKSHOP

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ABSTRACT

This workshop aims to bring together members from the NORDES community interested in work relating to environmental urgency, regenerative practices and the affective dimensions of design. Participants will collectively reflect on the affective dimensions of their design practice when engaging with ecological/sustainability transitions and explore the values in which they root their designerly practice. Through engaging with the relationality between the breadth of angles from which participants might understand the troubling experiences they encounter in this context, this workshop aims to bring participants to draw from their experiences and the epistemologies they work with to craft a manifesto regarding the affective dimensions of design practice in the context of the ecological transition.

WORKSHOP DESCRIPTION

In a world shaken by ecological crisis, we need to face uncomfortable realities, as people on this planet, but also as the designers we are – “Ease is not serving us” (Light et al., 2017, p.730). With this workshop we invite fellow designers/ practitioners, in the broadest sense of being transition facilitators, to a space for conversation. Together, we explore the in-between of affect, sustainability and (more-than) human experiences meeting in our practice. Diving into this space, where emotions meet practice, where conversations expose hidden troubles and ecological transitions require deep emotional engagement, we collectively inquire how feelings and affect shape (ecological) transition processes, how we as designers/researchers/practitioners see our role in engaging with and inviting others to take part in this, and how the affective shapes our design and research practices. We call designers/researchers/practitioners interested in relationality and affective landscapes (of



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grief/hope) in ecological transitions to bring together our perspectives on these topics that sometimes feel like ‘paradoxes’ and affective dead-ends.

We engage in conversation to explore others’ approaches to engage with similar challenges in their practice, sparking from our own troubles in more-than-human design and design for sustainable transitions:

> *Femke is troubled by the affective dimensions of processes of breakdown and phase out in sustainability transitions, in particular surrounding lost futures and emerging hopes.*
>
> *Anna is troubled by the concealed workings of feelings, or affective resonances and dissonances, in pedagogical practices of learning to live with and in the ecological crisis.*
>
> *Daphné is troubled by the place we give to our subjective experience within academic research, in particular when it comes to affective dimensions of our experience, and how we can express these dimensions within academia.*

From our personal standpoints we want to embrace diversity of theoretical and practical angles in this conversation, each participant brining their own troubles. Therefore, we wonder, as a starting point: what are you troubled by, when it comes to navigating the affective dimensions of regenerative practices? How do you engage with the in-between? Through engaging with an auto-ethnographical exercise along the idea of affective event writing (Kofoed & Fritsch, 2023), we will first explore our individual troubles navigating this landscape. This will be the basis for collective reflection and a mapping of the affective design practices we then build through our conversations. In this landscape, we will explore the relationality and reflect on questions of ‘What do we want to include in our practice? What do we want to watch out for in our practice? What values should we hold on to?’

Moving from understanding the landscape of practices we can together engage in collective manifesto writing, which serves as a message to ourselves in navigating this landscape. The manifesto portrays a snapshot of these designers/researchers/practitioners engaging with the affective dimensions in sustainability transitions and the role of design practice within those and allows a glance at the implicit knowledge within design practice revolving around more-than-human epistemologies and sustainability transitions.

AFFECTIVE DIMENSIONS OF ECOLOGICAL TRANSITIONS

The intimately personal dimensions of transitions and how these transitions manifest in daily lives are often overlooked, even though the affective attachments to these transitions shed light on the human dimensions of change. In recent years, more and more scholars have started reflecting on the critical role of affect in sustainability transitions (e.g., Bogner et al., 2024), recognizing the need to move beyond studying merely technological innovations, policy frameworks and institutional change as a gateway to change.

This turn towards affect theory reflects a broader understanding that sustainability transitions are not just systematic challenges, but deeply emotional and embodied processes that contain feelings of hope, loss, grief and frustration. Sustainability transitions cannot be seen as disconnected from our personal lives and lived experiences. Both humans and more than humans shape systems as much as they are being shaped by them. Affect theory helps us to understand how feelings travel between bodies, objects, and social structures, shaping experiences and power dynamics. Take for example Sara Ahmed’s work on ‘collective feelings’ (2004; 2013) where Ahmed argues that emotions are not just individual psychological states but social and cultural practices that create impressions, leaving marks upon bodies and shaping how we relate to others and the world. Or Ann Cvetkovich’s work on ‘Depression: A Public Feeling’ where Cvetkovich challenges our understanding of

depression as a medical condition or personal failing and argues to consider it as a cultural and political phenomenon, an affective response to systemic inequalities and historical traumas (2020).

Blanche Verlie points to the emotionally burdening understanding from acknowledging the human role in climate change, its irreversibility, and the human responsibility in it. Emotions such as denial, disengagement, or apathy and feelings of anxiety, frustration, grief, and guilt can surface, and create a certain affective atmosphere around engaging with the ecological crisis (Verlie, 2019; 2021).

Therefore, relational participatory design practices require "emotional involvement and management", which Yee et al. frame as often invisible labour in design processes (2024). They stress how working relationally thus not only requires the initiation and maintenance of relations to communities and individuals, but also a "becoming-with one another", where designers are part of their participants' (affective) journeys. We are picking up the thread of "emotion work" within design practices, which often goes unnoticed, as Balaam et al. point out, even though the affective attunement of design researchers with their participants is essential to grasping challenging matters, with feelings as the "core element of our work" (2019).

Complementing this theoretical context, we turn to manifesto writing as the core practice of this workshop. Manifesto writing is being used increasingly wide within design research, and we see the value in this practice to capture design practice in change:

> *"Design knowledge and practice is communal and collective. And we must share our worldviews—our design programs—in order to both be responsible for them and enable them to be challenged or appropriated by other designers and researchers in and beyond our context. With its political form, the manifesto is a suitable form for positioning and disseminating design research programs in an open, unstable and response-able way." (Søndergaard, 2018, p.158)*

RELEVANCE WITHIN RELATIONAL DESIGN

With design and design research having entered the world of entanglement, the engagement with worldly crises and relationalities, it also requires designers to reflectively adapt their practice to emerging challenges (Akama, 2017). The affective dimension of design processes engaging with the ecological transition brings troubling feelings into design spaces, which designers and other transition facilitators have to find ways to be responsive-to and responsible-with. Relational design approaches in the context of ecological transitions develop in-practice, and by expanding traditional (HCI) design methods, which might to large parts linger in the invisible (Yee et al., 2024). Making space and attending to troubling feelings from uncertain ecological transitions becomes increasingly important across several fields of design. In response, this workshop holds space to make such practices more explicit for the community of design practitioners and supports the further development of appropriate design approaches to ecological transitions.

Rethinking design research practices by engaging with the situated feelings of our design situations is essential for our practice to stay responsive and contribute to ecologically just futures. This workshop makes space for capturing ways in which design is affected by the changing world around and drive the articulation of an affective participatory design agenda in ecological transition contexts, like research agendas sketched for e.g. affective interaction design (Fritsch, 2018).

PRACTICALITIES AND ETHICAL CONCERNS

This three-hour in-person workshop will invite participants to reflect on uncomfortable feelings just as much as pleasant ones, whereas everyone decides themselves how much they want to share in each phase of the workshop. We will promote the creation of a brace space, in which each person contributes with equal respect for diverse backgrounds, epistomologies and world-views in the room.

As facilitating researchers, we will collect anonymous data from this workshop, in form of notes and images of materials. Registered participants will receive written and oral information about data collection and management ahead of the workshop. We consider all material produced in the workshop as collectively owned by all participants, and will discuss further shared outputs based on it at the workshop.

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